

Grappling with God, Part 2

PRIMARY TEXT: GENESIS 32–35

When we reflect back on our lives, what will we see? The damage of our unchecked *chutzpah*? A lack of faith and fire? What it costs us? How we wrestled with God—letting Him rename us? The power of our lives being used by God to change the world for the better? Maybe even a mix of all of these—and more.

**... letting Him
use our
chutzpah in
ways that bless
the world**

Will we see how we submitted ourselves, even our *chutzpah*, to God? Or will we see how our selfishness partially destroyed us, dousing our fire?

I hope to see how we bent to God's will, letting him *use* our *chutzpah* in ways that bless the world, and not just our own lives, but the lives of generations that come after us.

These four chapters of Genesis cover such a large chunk of Jacob's life. But the trajectory of it, and how it isn't a straight, uphill route to ultimate perfection, is so important to see as one cohesive story, rather than broken up into multiple separate narratives.

It can become so easy to choose a story and point out the good (or bad) in a person. To experience the short "Sunday School"-esque takeaway moment, and then obligate ourselves to live up to a standard, expecting to achieve "X" outcome. But, as Jacob's story shows, life's messes cannot be neatly tied up with a cute little bow or one wrestling match. That's not what the Story tells us.

**Life's messes
cannot be neatly
tied up with a cute
little bow or one
wrestling match.**

Jacob wrestled with God, God blesses and renames him, and "ta-da!"—he is forgiven by his brother. Problems solved!

The Israel who fought with God is the same Jacob who ran from his brother.

The Israel who fathered the twelve tribes of God's people is the same Jacob who played favorites with his wives and sons and family.

The Israel who God blessed at Bethel is the same Jacob who cursed the one with stolen idols—possibly leading to the death of his beloved wife.

Yet, Jacob's story doesn't end there. We often forget he is renamed more than once because of his *chutzpah*, and his life becomes a struggle itself between these names—*heel grasper; liar* OR *one who struggles with God; contender*.

Israel's name jumps back and forth throughout the rest of his story—just like our experiences and decisions do to us today. Just like unchecked *chutzpah*, there is danger in not seeing or understanding the whole story, but there is also so much hope and possibility in that our story, *your* story, isn't over yet.

So, like Jacob...

May you continue to wrestle.
Wrestle with what the world calls you and the calling God has placed on you.

**There is so much
hope and possibility
in that our story, *your*
story, isn't over yet.**

May you continue to contend.
To ask questions—big, difficult questions—and not be afraid to ask *what if* of the Text.

May you grow and transform and then grow and transform again as God leads you to the next chapter of your story—all wrapped up in the Story that is His.

May you reflect back on your life, and in between the moments of doubt or unchecked *chutzpah*, may you see the moments you wrestled with God. Where He reminded you, over and over again, that He sees you, He knows you, and you are loved.

PRAYER

*God of Israel,
You have called us to a life of wrestling.
Help us not to run from it.*

*May we never fear saying "what if"
May we never stop asking good questions
But may we always keep our fire in check.
Take our passion—our *chutzpah*
and let it be used for your Kingdom
as we continue to trust that our story, your Story,
isn't over yet.*

Amen.

THE FOUR PILLARS

EPISODE 14

BEMA Discipleship is built on four pillars; a **Four-Pillared Perspective** to help us remember **to elevate the words of God** (not ours) and help us identify the principles that we see recurring in the Story of God's people.

Here are some applications for this episode echoing the ideas of the four pillars:



TEXT

How could you meditate over these parts of the Story? What Text could you continue to meditate on, memorize, or dig deeper into?



COMMUNITY

In what ways does your community encourage your chutzpah, yet help it be used in ways that better the Kingdom? How could authentic community contribute to healthy fire and chutzpah that God can use?



DISCIPLESHIP

Who in your life would benefit from a mentor-like relationship that helps them use their chutzpah well? Someone who wants their fire to not go unchecked? What might the young people around you need to hear or see modeled?



WRESTLING

What questions do you have after this lesson? Why Jacob? Why wrestle and struggle and not straightforward answers? Why the lack of Jacob in his daughter's story? What sits uncomfortably still? Don't be afraid to struggle with the questions or what-ifs!



Are you a music listener?

Listen along to our BEMA Music Playlists on Spotify.

Song suggestions? Send them to bemabesorah@gmail.com.



BEMA SESSION 1



MEDITATION & PRAYER

REFLECTION, APPLICATION & IMPACT

There are three emphases we are always thinking about in terms of application at BEMA. These may be stated explicitly at times, but often we will want you to do the work of finding ways to connect the dots to the things we are learning. Much of this is what makes the work of BEMA distinct as a ministry of Impact Campus Ministries.

CREATING A SPACE SPIRITUAL FORMATION

*We believe that **if we do our part of creating space for God, He will fill it.** We want BEMA to foster practices that enable the Holy Spirit to do a work in and through us all. Creating space to wrestle with God and let Him fill it helps us become more willing and able to hear His voice. What different spiritual disciplines or discipleship assist in creating this space? Study, prayer, fasting, meditation, etc. Where do you seem to meet or find God? He is there.*

CONSIDERING CAMPUS YOUNG PEOPLE FOCUS

*We believe young adults are shaping the future of **this world**, and they need the mentorship or guidance of people like you. In what ways could you come alongside young adults to show them what it means to have chutzpah but keep it in check? How might they learn from wrestling alongside someone with the Text and their place in the world, rather than on their own?*

SACRED STATION THEOLOGY OF WORK

*This isn't just for our time at church or Bible study; this is about what we do at work every day. How we do our job and how we may use our chutzpah to bring life to others is something God says is central to our presence in the world. Does our physical work (our 9–5 job) bring shalom or chaos? How might our chutzpah impact this part of our life? Does it “burn” those we come into contact with? The way we manage our employees, interact with customers or coworkers, care for our children, or create products can bless others. **The work we do every day is sacred and matters!***